however, announced that were he to make a formal request, he would be permitted entry as a confirmed *bhakt* of Lord Krishna).

HINDUISM AS CULTURE

It is to a great degree possible to speak of Hinduism as culture rather than as religion (a distinction the votaries of Hindutva distort in extolling Savarkar's enunciation of a similar view). The inauguration of a public project, the laying of a foundation stone or the launching of a ship usually start with the ritual smashing of a coconut, an auspicious practice in Hinduism but one which most Indians of other faiths cheerfully accept in much the same spirit as teetotallers acknowledge the role of champagne in a Western celebration. Interestingly, similar Hindu customs have survived in now-Muslim Java and now-Buddhist Thailand. Islamic Indonesians still cherish the *Ramayana* legend, now shorn (for them) of its religious associations. Javanese Muslims bear Sanskrit names. Hindu culture can easily be embraced by non-Hindus if it is separated from religious faith and treated as a heritage to which all may lay claim. I have often argued that the *Mahabharata* and the *Ramayana* should be taught in our schools just as the *Odyssey* and the *Iliad* are in Western ones, not as religious texts but as towering accomplishments of our culture and the source of so many legends and cultural references.

Amartya Sen is right to stress that Hinduism is not simply the Hindutva of Ayodhya or Gujarat; it has left all Indians a religious, philosophical, spiritual and historical legacy that gives meaning to the civilisational content of secular Indian nationalism. In building an Indian nation that takes account of the country's true Hindu heritage, we have to return to the pluralism of the national movement. This must involve turning away from the strident calls for Hindutva that would privilege a doctrinaire view of Hinduism at the expense of the minorities, because such calls are a denial of the essence of the Hinduism of Vivekananda. I say this not as a godless secularist, but as a proud Hindu who is mortified at what his own faith is being reduced to in the hands of bigots—petty men who know little about the beliefs, the traditions and the history of the faith in whose 'defence' they claim to act. They have distorted a